

I Am a Rock

Paul Simon

Responding to Style

1. Simon makes effective use of figurative techniques. For instance, how is a fortress that “none may penetrate” both positive and negative? Furthermore, why does Simon choose a rock as his dominant metaphor? Explain, and then find additional examples of figurative language in the lyrics and comment on their effectiveness.

Responding Critically

2. How can books and poetry protect someone?
3. What two adjectives, in your opinion, best describe the speaker? Explain.
4. Name two things that have caused the speaker to isolate himself. How might these two things have hurt him? Speculate on what occurred.
5. Simon’s song was written and recorded in the mid-1960s. If not books and poetry, what modern luxuries might a person use to protect himself from the world? Discuss.
6. Paul Simon’s lyrics may be based on the excerpt from John Donne’s *Meditation xvii*, but the song seems to contradict Donne’s message. Explain how the words of the chorus and verses appear to contradict Donne’s message, then comment on the ending of the song. How does the ending affect the meaning of the lyrics as a whole?

Responding Creatively

7. Design an illustration for this song, one that could be used as an album cover. Concentrate on conveying your meaning through colour, line, texture, and/or balance. Write a paragraph-length explanation of how you used one of the elements above to create your message.